

Deck Design Principles

Defines the principles. Contents

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1. Purpose

What is Switchplay?

Switchplay is a system for helping people achieve meaningful goals by turning experience into simple, reusable paths. Rather than simply providing advice or information, Switchplay structures a transformation into a series of manageable steps that can be followed, adapted and shared. The fundamental unit of knowledge in Switchplay is the deck—a reusable path that captures not only what to do, but how someone successfully navigated a real journey.

Why does it exist?

People have access to more information and advice than ever before, yet making sustained progress towards meaningful goals remains difficult. Switchplay exists to bridge the gap between inspiration and action by helping users turn overwhelming goals into simple, structured paths that are easier to follow, reflect on and build upon. As users gain experience, they can package their own journeys into decks, allowing others to adapt those paths for themselves.

Achievers & Mentors

Switchplay has two primary user types. Achievers use decks to make progress towards their own goals by discovering, adapting and following paths. Mentors package their own experience into reusable decks so that others can benefit from their journey. These are not fixed roles but stages in the same lifecycle. The long-term vision is that today's Achievers become tomorrow's Mentors.

Simple steps. Achieve goals. Share paths.

This simple progression captures the core philosophy of Switchplay. Simple steps – break meaningful transformations into manageable actions. Achieve goals – help users make sustained progress through those steps. Share paths – enable experienced users to package their journeys into reusable decks that help others achieve similar transformations. The primary value of Switchplay is helping people make progress through simple, well-structured paths. Sharing those paths creates a growing community where today's Achievers become tomorrow's Mentors.

2. Design Philosophy

Simplicity

Simplicity is a fundamental design principle of Switchplay. Every aspect of a deck should reduce unnecessary complexity and make meaningful progress feel approachable. Complexity should only be introduced where it provides clear value. The goal is not to oversimplify a transformation, but to make it easier to understand, begin and sustain.

A Deck Should Answer A Question

Every deck should answer a single, meaningful question. The question defines the transformation the deck exists to support and provides the foundation for the deck title, streams, cards and steps. A strong question gives the entire deck a clear sense of purpose.

Decks Are Organised Around Transformations, Not Activities

A strong deck is organised around a transformation rather than a list of activities. The AI and the creator should first identify the underlying change the deck is trying to produce. The structure of the deck should then emerge from that understanding. For this reason, streams should rarely be simple categories of work. Instead, they should represent the key dimensions, tensions or conditions that together enable the transformation.

Capture Lived Experience

The most valuable decks are rarely those with the greatest technical depth. They are the ones that communicate the creator's lived experience. Good public decks capture more than information. They capture perspective, judgement and lessons learnt through experience. Rather than simply teaching people what to do, they explain why it matters, what commonly goes wrong, what finally made things click, and the way of thinking that made the transformation possible.

Communicate a Way of Thinking

A strong deck communicates more than a sequence of actions. It also passes on a way of thinking about the transformation. The most memorable decks help users understand not only what to do, but why it matters, how to approach it, and the judgement behind the decisions being made. This philosophy should emerge naturally through the deck's question, streams, cards and steps, giving the user a deeper understanding of the journey rather than simply a list of tasks to complete.

3. Anatomy of a Deck

Deck Question

Every deck begins with a question. The question defines the transformation the deck exists to support and provides the foundation for the title, streams, cards and steps. A strong question should be something that the user genuinely wants answered through experience rather than explanation.

Deck Title

The deck title is the shortest and most memorable description of the transformation the deck offers. It should complement the deck question rather than repeat it, giving the user an immediate sense of what the journey is about.

Writing Principles

Keep titles short (typically 2–5 words). Make them memorable and easy to recommend. Prefer describing the transformation, aspiration or experience rather than the activity or technique. Prefer meaningful change over technical terminology. Avoid generic labels that could apply to almost any deck. When choosing between a title that describes the work and one that describes what the work enables, prefer the latter.

Design Test

Ask yourself: "What would make somebody want to start this deck?" A strong title should communicate the value of the journey rather than simply describe the tasks involved. For example: Prefer: • Play Higher, Stay Traditional • Build Momentum • Make Healthy Habits Feel Automatic, Over: • Learn Second Position • Healthy Habits • Fitness Routine

Streams

Streams represent the three continuous dimensions of progress that run through the journey. Every card develops each stream a little further. Together, the streams carry the user towards the overall transformation. Good streams are not simply categories of work. They usually represent the key dimensions, tensions or conditions that together make the transformation possible. As a general rule, if one stream could be removed and the transformation would still succeed, it probably was not a true stream.

Cards

Cards represent meaningful stages within the journey. A deck typically contains four cards, each representing approximately one week of progress. However, cards may represent stages rather than time where this better reflects the transformation. Each card should move every stream forward and feel like a meaningful step in the overall journey.

Steps

Each card contains one step for each stream. Steps should be short, clear and meaningful. Rather than simply describing tasks to complete, they should encourage actions, behaviours or ways of approaching the period ahead. Good steps should naturally invite reflection. They should give the user a clear sense of what meaningful progress would look like without defining a formal measurement system. As a simple test: Could a user meaningfully reflect on this step at the end of the card? If the answer is no, the step is probably too vague, too binary or too narrowly task-focused.

Writing Guidelines

The aim is clarity rather than completeness. Keep all writing concise, easy to scan and focused on the transformation. Suggested limits: As a general rule: If removing a word does not reduce meaning, remove it.

4. Designing Strong Decks

Card Count

A Switchplay deck typically contains four cards. This provides enough time for meaningful progression while remaining approachable and easy to complete. Longer or shorter decks may occasionally be appropriate where the transformation naturally requires them, but creators should avoid making decks longer than necessary.

Progression Principles

Every card should represent a meaningful step in the overall transformation. Progression should feel natural rather than imposed, with each card building upon what came before. By the end of the deck, the user should feel they have undergone a coherent journey rather than completed a collection of unrelated tasks.

Stream Progression

Each stream should tell its own story across the deck. Reading a single stream from the first card to the last should reveal a clear progression in understanding, behaviour, confidence or capability. A deck should therefore make sense both: Horizontally – how all three streams work together within each card. Vertically – how each stream develops across the journey. This is one of the hallmarks of a well-designed deck.

Streams Represent Different Dimensions of Progress

Strong streams are rarely simple categories of work. Instead, they represent the key dimensions, tensions or conditions that together make the transformation possible. For example: A healthy habits deck is stronger when organised around: • Find Your Thing • Build Consistency • Let Momentum Spread, than around: • Gym • Nutrition • Walking Similarly, a music deck is stronger when organised around: • Relaxed Technique • New Musical Possibilities • Musical Judgement, than around individual techniques or positions.

Some Streams Are Naturally More Objective

Some streams naturally focus on observable outcomes such as strength, speed, attendance or technical accuracy. Where this reflects the nature of the transformation, it should be embraced rather than avoided.

Some Streams Are Naturally More Subjective

Other streams naturally focus on lived experience, such as confidence, calmness, judgement, enjoyment or clarity. These are equally valuable and should not be forced into artificial objectivity. The nature of the stream should reflect the nature of the transformation.

Designing Good Steps

Good steps are: • simple • clear • meaningful • easy to reflect upon. Rather than simply describing tasks to complete, they should encourage meaningful actions, behaviours or ways of approaching the period ahead. Avoid turning steps into SMART goals or checklists. Instead, write them in a way that naturally encourages reflection and sustained engagement throughout the card.

Steps Should Suggest Meaningful Progress

Although deck templates no longer define explicit signals, good steps naturally suggest the kinds of evidence that indicate meaningful progress. The purpose is not to create a measurement system, but to help the user recognise what "going well" might look like. For example: Bench press may naturally suggest increasing strength or confidence. Reaching out to potential clients may naturally suggest stronger conversations or growing momentum. Experimenting with higher positions in a tune may naturally suggest discovering musical moments that genuinely improve the music. As a simple test, ask: If this step went really well, what would the user notice? A strong step usually has an obvious answer, even if it is never explicitly written into the deck.

Cards Do Not Need To Represent Project Phases

Cards do not need to follow a standard project structure such as: Plan → Build → Launch → Review. Instead, they should reflect the natural progression of the transformation. Some decks progress through weeks. Others progress through stages, shifts in emphasis, increasing confidence or growing fluency. The structure should emerge from the journey itself rather than being imposed upon it.

5. Advanced Deck Design

Cross-Deck Reinforcement

A user may work on multiple decks simultaneously. Well-designed decks should naturally reinforce one another, allowing progress in one area of life to support progress in another. This should be viewed as a strength rather than something to avoid.

Different Decks Can Observe the Same Action

The same real-world action may appear in multiple decks while serving different purposes. For example, going to the gym might represent: • rehabilitation in one deck, • consistency in another, • confidence in a

third. The meaning of a step is determined by the transformation the deck is trying to create, not by the action itself.

Cross-Deck Steps Can Act As Confirmation

Progress made in one deck may provide confidence or evidence that supports another. These relationships should emerge naturally rather than through explicit dependencies. Each deck should remain complete and meaningful on its own while benefiting from progress elsewhere.

Core Assets & Flexible Assets

Some assets continue to support many different transformations throughout life. Examples include: • physical health • confidence • supportive relationships • financial stability • learning habits. These are core assets. Other assets are valuable only within particular journeys, such as: • a qualification • a prototype • a competition • a portfolio piece. These are flexible assets. Strong deck design recognises the interaction between long-term core assets and short-term goals while maintaining a clear focus on the transformation each individual deck is intended to support.

General Principle

Advanced design should only be introduced where it genuinely strengthens the user's journey. Every deck should first be capable of standing on its own. Simplicity remains the guiding principle throughout Switchplay.